

Kamalini Paul: Managing Director, Hotel De Sovrani Leading With Firepower And Foresight

She debunked the twitterings of the naysayers when, on the sudden demise of her father, as a 19-year-old college kid, Managing Director, Hotel De Sovrani, was compelled to grasp the monumental task of reassembling the life her mother and two smaller siblings

What her father had left behind was a headless real estate business which he had built from the bottom up in West Bengal, and a foray into the hospitality sector with a business hotel.

Her attempt to take his place at the head of the realty team met with hostility fuelled by gender and age bias. To make matters worse, with no mentor to lean on and weighed down by her personal loss, she had to tackle major financial losses and legal hurdles, and prop up the newly established business hotel—De Sovrani.

The realty business is no cake walk even for veteran players. And Kamalini was an untried fledgling in an environment fraught with unknown challenges. But her sense of responsibility and a hardening determination to ride the storm gave her courage. She decided to first focus on the emergent business hotel, instead of drowning in the maelstrom of complexities of managing the real estate business.

Those early days have been pivotal in honing Ms Paul's skills as an entrepreneur and savvy businesswoman. She sets the narrative right for those who today imagine she had it easy. The reality was that her journey was filled with hurdles galore— and a lot of blood, sweat and tears no doubt, while navigating her way to the right path. "Honestly, I wouldn't change a thing; those challenges taught me how to spot

opportunities even when they were hard to see," she says.

Her quest for creating a new life for her family was driven by a steely resolve and innovative bent of mind, which is how she transformed De Sovrani into one of Kolkata's premier upscale independent hotels. It continues to enjoy that success to date.

Her native resilience was tested once again, when the pandemic wrought havoc across the hospitality sector. Kamalini was just 24 at the time. By now she had weathered many storms and that training helped her take on the pandemic challenges head on. She floated Food Aaj Kal, a quick-service restaurant chain, and POZ Hotels, a budget-friendly hospitality brand. The buoyancy of the two ventures in these turbulent times further proved Ms Paul's mettle as a smart businesswoman.

She pulled another rabbit out of her commodious hat— this time it was the Serra Café, Kolkata's first automatic retractable rooftop café; it became an instant hit.

In time she was ready to return to the real estate business. She did this by launching the Paulis Business Tower, a modern business center with office spaces, meeting rooms, and conference facilities. Today, a slew of top Indian brands has their offices here.

Ms Paul's personal experiences on the workfront inspired her passionate advocacy for workspace gender equity. She also works for the less privileged, contributing to com-

munity development, and championing animal welfare. She also partners with policy and community groups in Bengal to create a lasting difference.

Ms Paul was bestowed the APJ Abdul Kalam Award of Excellence in 2023 and feted as the Young Women Entrepreneur of the Year 2020-21 by Bengal Chambers of Commerce.

